with journalist Alia Allana, offers a peek into exclusively commissioned photography and spans the quantum of Tahiliani's life from his early years, the launch of the iconic Ensemble in 1987 that gave Indian designers a platform for the first time, to the eventual culmination of the legacy he has created with his eponymous label and brand since 1995. "*Journey to India Modern* was also to show that in our society, we rely principally on the drape form and a little thing called a *nada patti* which can be seen on a churidar, petticoat or on the back of a choli," he adds.

Reminiscing about his showcase at the Milan Fashion Week way back in 2003, Tahiliani says they were the first designers to show from India. "It was a catalyst to doing modern clothes...I started the show in Milan with just a sari and ended it with three lehengas. There was a whole world in between...wrap corsets, jodhpur trousers, chikankari pantsuits and more. We were ahead of our time."

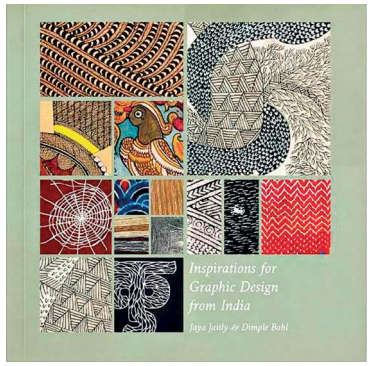
Tahiliani admits to having drifted to embroideries over time but he continues to be excited about the possibilities of everyday wear. "My next project is to start a really cool ready-to-wear line using just one element. Wouldn't someone love to wear a plain shirt with a fine chikan collar that can be paired with a skirt, sari or pants?"

It's not just this collection that has him on his toes but also a standalone museum show, to be held in February 2025 at the Asian Civilisations Museum, Singapore. "We are juxtaposing work with beautiful treasures from the museum," he says. Tahiliani is also dressing a philanthropist at the Met Gala, the biggest night in fashion. "I never thought so much effort goes into one dress and look...in that sense, it is fashion's biggest parade," he says. ■

–Geetika Sachdev

Indic Arts

An eye-catching repository of quintessentially Indian design elements



INSPIRATIONS FOR GRAPHIC DESIGN FROM INDIA,
by Jaya Jaitly & Dimple Bahl
ARTHSHILA TRUST
₹1,500; 156 pages

Inspirations for Graphic Design from India **is a beautifully produced book, revelling in the many luscious examples of the traditional crafts of India. They are a delight in design, colour and boldness, and filled with an undeniable graphic quality.**

This is of interest for two reasons. First, many of these are living traditions, threatened by industrialisation but conserved by the efforts of governments since the 1950s, especially in the area of textiles. These efforts have now taken root, and these traditional designs are being welcomed into modern living, going beyond the urban elite that first eagerly consumed them. The traditional and the modern are in a creative tension that we are navigating in our own ways, every day.

Along with this, the design commentariat, perhaps exhausted by modernism, or consumed by an aching for its roots, often cries out for an 'Indian' design idiom. The relevance of this is a fraught subject too large for this space. But from it arises a tendency to quote, to copy and paste, traditional art into modern containers. Such quotation is not assimilation, where an influence is internalised and not obvious, which *sookshma drishti* (a subtle vision) alone could recognise as *prerana*, the breath of inspiration in the design, rather than becoming its body or decorating its surface.

The book's title may suggest such an exploration. It presents its body of works as examples of the *bindu* (point/dot), *rekha* (line), *aakar* (form) and several others. These overlap with the foundational elements used to teach graphic design in the European birthplaces of modern graphic design education. What could be more fundamental? To be reminded that a line divides–and creates texture–is useful refresher material to any designer, and revelatory to the interested non-designer.

The introduction tells us that these design fundaments were known to the ancients, but I did not find wonder at this; I would have been surprised if the ancients, always smart fellows, had not thought these up. At other times, the commentary offers a stripping of the design element down to its very metaphysics. Coupled with the Sanskritic and other sources, they may serve to impress or mystify rather than enlighten.

But don't let my scepticism stop you. This book, with its traditional and contemporary examples, repurposes the traditional design arts of India. It is also a gateway to other collections and books, and a compact source of inspiration. Of course, the pleasure of looking is its own reward. ■

–Itu Chaudhuri

To be reminded that a line divides, and creates texture, is useful refresher material to any designer